

Statements & Conclusions

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Statements-and-conclusions questions give one or more factual statements and one or more numbered conclusions, asking whether each conclusion 'follows' logically and necessarily from the statement(s) alone — using ONLY the information given, never outside knowledge, personal opinion, or real-world plausibility. This is the same strict-necessity discipline used in syllogisms, but applied to plain-language factual statements rather than formal All/No/Some categories, and it frequently trips up candidates who let real-world knowledge override what the statement actually says. The standard answer format asks whether only conclusion I follows, only II, both, either, or neither. This sub-module covers the core 'follows strictly from the given data' rule, the distinction between a conclusion and an assumption, handling numerical/ comparative statements, either-or (complementary) conclusion pairs, multi-statement combinations, and the classic trap of conclusions that are true in reality but not derivable from the statement as written.

1. The Core Rule: Follows Strictly From Given Data Only

A conclusion 'follows' only if it can be derived using nothing but the words of the statement(s) plus basic logic — real-world truth, common sense, or outside facts about the subject matter are irrelevant and must be deliberately set aside, even when a conclusion happens to also be true in reality.

- Statement: 'All the mangoes in this basket are ripe.' Conclusion: 'The mangoes in this basket are sweet.' Even though ripe mangoes are usually sweet in real life, the statement never mentions sweetness — this conclusion does NOT follow from the given statement alone.

2. Conclusion vs Assumption: The Key Difference

A conclusion is derived by moving FORWARD from the statement (what can we validly infer), while an assumption is something that must be true BEHIND the statement for it to make sense in the first place (see the Statements & Assumptions sub-module) — a conclusion restates or logically extends given information, whereas an assumption fills a gap the statement leaves silent.

- Statement: 'Ravi always carries an umbrella when it rains.' Valid conclusion: 'If it is raining and Ravi is outside, he likely has an umbrella with him' (a direct extension). This is different from an assumption like 'Ravi owns an umbrella,' which the statement takes for granted rather than concludes.

3. Numerical and Comparative Statement Conclusions

When statements give numeric or comparative facts, a conclusion follows only if it's a direct, unavoidable consequence of the given numbers — a conclusion requiring an extra numeric assumption (like an average, a 'most likely' value, or an unstated total) does not strictly follow.

- Statement: 'There are 30 students in a class; 18 are girls.' Conclusion: 'There are 12 boys in the class.' This DOES follow strictly ($30 - 18 = 12$, pure arithmetic on given numbers). Conclusion: 'More girls than boys attended a recent trip.' This does NOT follow — attendance at a trip is never mentioned.

4. Either-Or (Complementary) Conclusion Pairs

Just as in syllogisms, when neither of two conclusions follows individually, but the statement guarantees that at least one of the two possibilities MUST be true (they're mutually exclusive and jointly exhaustive given the statement), the correct answer is 'either I or II follows.'

- Statement: 'Either the train is late, or it has already departed.' Conclusion I: 'The train is late.' Conclusion II: 'The train has already departed.' Neither follows individually (we don't know which), but the statement guarantees one of the two is true — so 'either I or II follows' is correct.

5. Multi-Statement Combinations

When multiple statements are given together, a conclusion may follow from combining them even if it doesn't follow from any single statement alone — check whether the conclusion can be chained through the statements the same way a multi-step syllogism chain works, using each statement as one link.

- Statement 1: 'All members of the committee are professors.' Statement 2: 'Dr. Rao is a member of the committee.' Conclusion: 'Dr. Rao is a professor.' This follows validly by chaining: Dr. Rao " committee (statement 2), committee ", professors (statement 1), therefore Dr. Rao " professors.

6. The Classic Trap: True in Reality, But Not Derivable

The single most common wrong answer selects a conclusion that's plausible or factually true in the real world but isn't actually supported by the specific wording of the given statement — always re-read the statement's exact wording before confirming a conclusion, checking specifically whether the conclusion introduces any claim, comparison, or category the statement never made.

- Statement: 'The new policy has reduced traffic accidents in the city by 20% this year.' Conclusion: 'The new policy is effective at improving road safety.' This sounds obviously true, but strictly, the statement only reports a correlation (accidents dropped after the policy) — it doesn't state the policy CAUSED the drop, so a strict-conclusion question may correctly judge this as not following, depending on how narrowly 'effective' is being tested.

Common Pitfalls

- Judging a conclusion by whether it sounds true in real life instead of whether it's strictly derivable from the statement's own wording.
- Confusing a conclusion (forward inference from the statement) with an assumption (unstated premise behind the statement).
- Introducing an extra unstated numeric assumption (like an average or 'most') when only exact given numbers support a conclusion.
- Missing an either-or (complementary) conclusion pair by evaluating each candidate conclusion only in isolation.
- Failing to chain multiple given statements together when a conclusion only follows from combining them, not from either statement alone.
- Accepting a causal conclusion ('X caused Y') when the statement only supports a correlational or sequential fact.
- Overlooking that a conclusion restating the statement in different words still 'follows' — rejecting it for sounding 'too obvious.'

Key Takeaways

- A conclusion must follow STRICTLY from the given statement's wording alone — real-world plausibility is irrelevant and must be set aside.
- Conclusions move forward from the statement (inference); assumptions sit behind it (unstated premise) — never conflate the two.
- Numeric conclusions must be exact, direct consequences of given numbers — no averages, estimates, or unstated totals allowed.
- Check for either-or (complementary) conclusion pairs whenever two candidates are mutually exclusive and together cover all given possibilities.
- A conclusion can follow from combining multiple statements even when it doesn't follow from any single one alone — chain them.
- Be wary of causal-sounding conclusions when the statement only reports a correlation or a sequence of events.

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